SEMPLICE ITALIAN KITCHEN | PASTA, RISOTTO & GNOCCHI

# Authentic Roman Pasta alla Gricia (20-Minute Zero-Clump Cheese Paste Method)

**PREP: 5 mins | COOK: 15 mins | TOTAL: 20 mins | SERVINGS: 4 servings | CALORIES: 560 kcal**

## INGREDIENTS

* 400g (14 oz) Bronze-die Rigatoni or Mezze Maniche
* 170g (6 oz) Guanciale (or Unsmoked Pancetta) (cut into 1/4-inch thick batons)
* 115g (1.25 cups) Pecorino Romano DOP (finely grated on a microplane)
* 2 tsp Whole Black Peppercorns (coarsely crushed)
* 2 tbsp (30ml) Dry White Wine (Optional) (to deglaze the guanciale skillet)

## STEP-BY-STEP INSTRUCTIONS

**Step 1: Boil Rigatoni in Low-Volume Water (8 mins)**

Bring 2.5 quarts (2.4L) of water to a boil with only 1 teaspoon of salt (Pecorino and guanciale provide all the salt you need). Add the rigatoni and cook until 2 minutes shy of al dente.

**Step 2: Render Guanciale from a Cold Skillet (8 mins)**

Place the guanciale batons in a cold, wide stainless steel skillet and turn heat to medium-low. Cook slowly for 7-8 minutes until the fat renders clear and the batons are crisp on the outside and tender inside. Remove half the crispy guanciale to a plate for garnish. Add the crushed black pepper (and optional splash of white wine) to the remaining fat in the pan, swirling for 30 seconds.

**Step 3: Whisk the Warm Water & Pecorino Paste (2 mins)**

Scoop 1/2 cup of starchy pasta water into a heatproof measuring cup and let it cool for 45 seconds (to roughly 135F / 57C-warm to the touch, not boiling). Slowly whisk 4-5 tablespoons of this warm starchy water into a bowl containing the finely microplaned Pecorino Romano until a smooth, thick paste forms.

**Step 4: Finish Cooking Rigatoni in the Guanciale Emulsion (2 mins)**

Transfer the undercooked rigatoni into the skillet with the rendered guanciale fat and 1/3 cup of pasta water. Toss vigorously over high heat for 90 seconds until the starch and pork fat emulsify into a creamy glaze.

**Step 5: Fold in the Pecorino Paste Off Heat (1 mins)**

Remove the skillet from the stove and wait 45 seconds. Dollop in the Pecorino paste and toss rapidly with tongs, adding a splash of warm pasta water if needed until every rigatoni tube is glossy and velvety. Top with the reserved crispy guanciale and extra cracked pepper.

## NONNA’S CHEF TIPS:

- Letting the scooped pasta water cool for 45 seconds before whisking it into the Pecorino is the #1 secret that prevents cheese proteins from clumping.
- Never drain your pasta in a colander! Always transfer the rigatoni with a spider strainer so you keep the liquid gold starchy water right on the stove.